
"Unitatis Redintegratio" forty years after the Council

Author(s): Edward Idris Cardinal Cassidy

Source: *Gregorianum*, 2007, Vol. 88, No. 2 (2007), pp. 312-328

Published by: GBPress- Gregorian Biblical Press

Stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/23582467>

JSTOR is a not-for-profit service that helps scholars, researchers, and students discover, use, and build upon a wide range of content in a trusted digital archive. We use information technology and tools to increase productivity and facilitate new forms of scholarship. For more information about JSTOR, please contact support@jstor.org.

Your use of the JSTOR archive indicates your acceptance of the Terms & Conditions of Use, available at <https://about.jstor.org/terms>



is collaborating with JSTOR to digitize, preserve and extend access to
Gregorianum

JSTOR

Unitatis Redintegratio **forty years after the Council**

One of the areas in the life of the Catholic Church, in which the Second Vatican Council called for a radical new approach, was undoubtedly that of Christian Unity. When the Council Fathers assembled in Rome in 1962, the majority certainly came with the understanding that basically such unity could only be achieved by the return to the Catholic Church of those other Christian communities who had separated themselves from its fold over the millennium that was fast coming to a close.

Already fifty years earlier, a number of Christian missionary organisations had at Edinburgh in June 1910 realised the harm that was being done by their divisions and competition to the work of bringing Christ's saving message to the world. Following this gathering, two international organisations were formed, *Faith and Order* and *Life and Work*, to promote unity and greater cooperation among Churches, and in 1949 these developed into the World Council of Churches. The Catholic Church, however, remained distant from these developments.

Catholics did nevertheless take part in the annual Week of Prayer for Christian Unity, and in the post Second World War years a number of Catholic bishops and theologians became interested in the developments toward unity within the other Christian communities and to question the traditional Catholic approach. In 1952 a Catholic Conference for Ecumenical Questions was set up by a group of twenty-four Catholic theologians meeting under the chairmanship of Bishop Charrière of Lausanne, Geneva and Fribourg. Jesuit professor Karl Rahner and Dominican theologian Yves Congar were prominent in this organisation. Earlier, from 1948 on, meetings had taken place between bishops, theologians and some Roman professors, at the initiative of two Dutch priests, Prof. Johannes Willebrands and Franz Thijssen. None of this, however, had reached most of the Catholic bishops who assembled in Rome for the opening of the Second Vatican Council on October 11th, 1962.

The Document

In his Opening Address to the Council, Pope John XXIII included a reflection that was to be of special importance in the theological dialogue that would follow the Council. I believe it is well to quote the whole of this passage, given its special significance for future dialogue:

The substance of the ancient doctrine of the deposit of faith is one thing, and the way in which it is presented is another. And it is the latter that must be taken into great consideration with patience if necessary, everything being measured in the forms and proportions of a magisterium which is predominantly pastoral in character.

The Catholic Church, raising the torch of religious truth by means of this Ecumenical Council, desires to show herself the loving mother of all, benign, patient, full of mercy and goodness towards the brethren who are separated from her.

From this, and other statements made by the Holy Father as the Council began, it was evident that he wished Christian Unity to have a special place on the agenda of the Second Vatican Council. Indeed, right from the first session, when documents on Liturgy and Sources of Revelation were discussed, Christian Unity often found a positive echo. The hope was expressed that liturgical renewal would play a role in advancing this cause. The document on the *Sources of Revelation* was recalled for revision as a result of the criticism expressed in the Council, and one element of that criticism was the fact that the text before the Assembly would not encourage dialogue with other Christians.

The first version of the decree on Ecumenism was shown to Pope John XXIII before he died. On his authority it was sent around the world to the Bishops for study and recommendations. The Secretariat for Christian Unity, which His Holiness had established, brought a revised document to the second Session of the Council. The document was discussed from 18 November to 2 December 1963. It contained five chapters:

- the first three dealt with the principles and practice of ecumenism, and relations with other Christian Communities;
- chapter four was dedicated to Catholic–Jewish relations; and
- chapter five to Religious Freedom.

On November 21, the Council was asked to vote on the first three chapters as providing a basis for further discussion. Of the Council Fathers present, 1970 voted in the affirmative with 86 against. Two questions – Relations with the Jews, and Religious Freedom – were taken out of the document to be treated in other documents.

During the third session, in 1964, the Council Fathers were presented with a *Decree on Ecumenism*. About one thousand changes and recommendations to the former document had in the meantime been examined. This

new version was voted by the Council Fathers on November 20, 1964, and approved by 2054 affirmative votes to 64 negative. In the ceremonial vote of November 21, 1964, only eleven negative votes were presented, and the document was promulgated that day. On the same day, the Council approved the Dogmatic Constitution on the Church. Any study of *Unitatis Redintegratio* needs to be accompanied by a reading both of the Dogmatic Constitution on the Church *Lumen Gentium*, and of the Declaration on Religious Freedom *Dignitatis Humanae*.

As the Council came to a close, on December 7, 1965, a first important fruit was received by the Roman Catholic and Orthodox Churches in the form of a Declaration removing «from memory and the midst of the Church the sentences of excommunication that had been levelled against each other in 1054». The sentence of excommunication levelled against Patriarch Michael Cerularius and two other persons by the Legates from Rome under the leadership of Cardinal Humbertus in that year had been followed by similar sentences pronounced by the Patriarch and the Synod of Constantinople against the Roman Legates. While the rupture of ecclesial communion came later, there is no doubt that the events of 1054 played a decisive role in this sad development.

In the document *Unitatis Redintegratio* (*The Restoration of Unity*), the Council Fathers came to the conclusion that «division among Christians openly contradicts the will of Christ, scandalizes the world, and damages the holy cause of preaching the Gospel to every creature» (UR 1). Members of other Christian communities were no longer to be seen as enemies or strangers, but as brothers and sisters, and this not just as a polite approach, but because «those who believe in Christ and have been truly baptized are in communion with the Catholic Church, even though this communion is imperfect» (UR 3).

Lest perhaps the Council's teaching might seem to apply to individual Christians, apart from their incorporation in a Christian community, the Council refers to the churches and communions not in full communion with the Catholic Church as possessing «many of the elements and endowments which go together and help to give life to the Church itself» (UR 3). While of course insisting on the teaching that the one, true Church can be found in the Catholic Church, the Council «exhorts all the Catholic faithful to recognize the signs of the times and to take an active and intelligent part in the work of ecumenism» and «commends this work to the bishops everywhere in the world to be vigorously stimulated by them and guided with prudence» (UR 4).

Implementation

There is of course much more to the Decree on Christian Unity *Unitatis Redintegratio* than I have indicated. But now as we reflect on the situation

regarding unity among the Christian communities, the question that occupies our thought is more concerned with the progress that has been made and the difficulties encountered on the ecumenical journey. This was done by Pope John Paul II in a special Encyclical Letter on Commitment to Ecumenism, *Ut Unum Sint*, in 1965.

In that document, Pope John Paul II indicates clearly the three pillars upon which our search for Christian Unity is to be based: prayer, common witness and theological dialogue. So we see at once that the work for Christian Unity is not something to be left to bishops, experts and theologians. As already mentioned, the Vatican Council exhorted the Catholic faithful everywhere to take an active and intelligent part in the work of ecumenism, and Pope John Paul II, in his Encyclical writes:

Thus it is absolutely clear that ecumenism [...] is not just some sort of 'appendix' which is added to the Church's traditional activity. Rather ecumenism is an organic part of her life and work, and consequently must pervade all that she is and does (UUS 20).

Since the Council, Ecumenism has become an essential part of the Catholic Church's mission. Indeed, today it is a priority for our Church. From being in 1960 a non-runner in the field, the Catholic Church is today right at the forefront among the runners. This is the result, among other things, of a personal commitment to the cause on the part of the two great Popes of the period, Paul VI and John Paul II. But it is also due to the accompanying work done at the regional and local levels by Bishops' Conferences, priests and laity.

In a number of places throughout the world, local Christian communities come together frequently to pray, especially during the annual Week of Prayer for Christian Unity, but also during Lent and Advent, and particularly on Good Friday. Pope John Paul II, taking up words written by Saint Augustine, reminds the reader that «when Christians pray together, the goal of unity seems closer [...]. In the fellowship of prayer Christ is truly present; he prays 'in us', 'with us' and 'for us'. It is he who leads our prayer in the Spirit-Consoler» (UUS 22).

The Holy Father assigns pride of place along the ecumenical path to common prayer and refers to his own experience of praying with the leaders of other Christian communities all over the world during his visits to various countries. In fact, Pope John Paul II always insisted on such meetings being included when his trips were being prepared.

The second pillar on which the ecumenical task is built is also one that can also take place at the local level, namely common witness or working together in order to make Christ's loving face more visible to the sick, the suffering and generally to all those in need of love and care. Pope John Paul II refers to this activity as a 'school of ecumenism', for there the Christian comes to know, respect and foster fellowship with other Christians. The

Faith and Order Commission of the World Council of Churches, meeting in Lund, Sweden, in 1952, challenged the Christian communities throughout the world for the sake of Christian Unity to «act together in all matters except those in which deep differences of conviction compel them to act separately». Surely, fifty years later, 'the Lund Principle' should be more widely applied at both the international and national levels.

By working together and through sincere attempts to understand each other, Catholics and other Christians have rediscovered – to use an expression of Pope John Paul II – their 'universal brotherhood'. We are, in fact, no longer strangers one to the other, and most certainly not enemies. In *Ut Unum Sint*, His Holiness states that the universal brotherhood of Christians has become a firm ecumenical conviction, and he insists that this is not to be seen as «the consequence of a large-hearted philanthropy or a vague family spirit, but is rooted in the one-ness of baptism» (UUS 42). Since Christians are baptized into the one body of Christ, they are by that act brought together as members of one family, the Christian family.

The third pillar, theological dialogue, is undoubtedly a crucial element in seeking to overcome the divisions of the past, and is undertaken only by those officially appointed to carry out such activity. Some very valuable work in this regard has been done by the special dialogue Commissions established at the national levels in the United States of America, in European countries, in Australia and other countries. This task at the international level is, for the Catholic Church, under the direction of the Pontifical Council for Promoting Christian Unity. This is done normally through contact and dialogue with the various Christian communities present through their international organisations. Over the past forty years, considerable progress has been made in theological dialogue between the Pontifical Council and the following bodies:

- the Oriental Orthodox Churches;
- the Orthodox Churches;
- the Anglican Communion;
- the Lutheran World Federation;
- the World Methodist Council;
- the World Alliance of Reformed Churches; and
- the Disciples of Christ (Christian Church).

There have also been valuable discussions with the Baptist World Alliance, the Mennonite World Conference, the Old Catholic Churches of the Union of Utrecht, some Classical Pentecostal Churches and Leaders, the World Evangelical Alliance, and the Seven Day Adventists. Regular meetings and discussions have taken place between the Pontifical Council and the World Christian Communities.

At the same time, the Catholic Church maintains close contact with the World Council of Churches in Geneva, and by means of a Joint Working

Group joins in regular discussions on questions of common interest. This body has produced a number of important documents. There is, moreover, special collaboration between the Catholic Church and the Faith and Order Commission of the World Council of Churches, which includes among its members twelve Catholic theologians. Foremost among the documents offered to the Ecumenical Movement by the Faith and Order Commission is that entitled: *Baptism, Eucharist and Ministry*.

The relationship and type of dialogue between the Catholic Church and the above-mentioned organisations differs greatly, according to the different historical and doctrinal elements present. The Catholic Church is closest doctrinally to the Oriental Orthodox and the Orthodox Churches, and much more distant in this regard from the Evangelical Churches, although at times Catholics and Evangelicals come together to give valuable common Christian witness to moral questions in the public forum. The dialogue has to take account of these facts. At the same time, the Pontifical Council considers each of these dialogues to be important and enters into discussion seriously. The dialogues have produced positive, and at times surprising, results. Only a few of their agreed statements, however, have been officially approved by the Catholic Church. Those so approved deserve special mention in this presentation.

The Catholic Church has, in the first place, succeeded in coming to a formal understanding with each of the Ancient Oriental Churches on one of the great questions that divided the Church already in the fifth century, namely the formulation of the doctrine concerning the two natures in Jesus Christ. It was the definition of the early Councils, and in particular the Council of Chalcedon (451), that led to the parting of the ways between the Oriental Orthodox Churches and the rest of the then Christian world. In contrast to the Chalcedonian formula of one person and two natures in Christ, these Churches affirmed the formula of Cyril of Alexandria, who spoke of «the one incarnate nature of the Word of God». For the Oriental Orthodox, those who accepted the Chalcedonian formula were seen as holding an essentially Nestorian Christology that compromised the unity of Christ's person. For those who accepted Chalcedon, the «one incarnate nature» formula of the Oriental Orthodox seemed indistinguishable from the monophysite position of Eutyches, who taught that Jesus' humanity was totally subsumed into his divinity.

Since the Second Vatican Council, it has been possible for the Catholic Church and the Patriarchs of these Churches to declare their common faith in Jesus Christ, true God and true man, putting aside 1500 years of controversy by stressing the common faith behind different expressions of that faith. Agreement was reached with the Syrian Church in 1971, with the Coptic Church in 1973, the Ethiopian Church in 1993, and with the Assyrian Church of the East in 1994 (cf. UUS 62). The 1996 common declaration of

Pope John Paul II and the Armenian Catholicos Karekin I spoke of their «fundamental common faith in God and in Jesus Christ». The principle upon which these agreements is based is that that already mentioned by Pope John XXIII at the opening of the Second Vatican Council, namely the distinction between what is believed as faith and how that belief is expressed. The value of this distinction has become clear over and over again in subsequent dialogue with other Churches.

A second major achievement in theological dialogue and in the search for Christian Unity was undoubtedly the signing in Augsburg, on October 31, 1999 of the *Joint Declaration on the Doctrine of Justification*, between the Catholic Church and the Lutheran World Federation. This was an outcome of the earlier work of the relative dialogue commission, and in particular of its third phase. After 30 years of serious bilateral theological and ecumenical dialogue, the *International Lutheran/Roman Catholic Commission for Unity* had come to the conviction that the two seemingly opposing understandings by Lutherans and Catholics of the doctrine of Justification could be reconciled. A Joint Declaration was drawn up and officially submitted by the Commission to the two Churches for approval, and then signed. This document has recently been accepted also by the World Methodist Council. Again, the principle of distinguishing between the faith and the expression of that faith proved of special importance. The discussion also made clear just how deeply particular expressions of faith become for each particular Christian community as time passes. The *Joint Declaration* has as its object one of the fundamental doctrinal questions at the heart of the whole Reformation, namely the relation of faith and good works in the work of justification. The basis of the agreement is found in N. 15 of the Joint Declaration:

Together we confess: By grace alone, in faith in Christ's saving work and not because of any merit on our part, we are accepted by God and receive the Holy Spirit, who renews our hearts while equipping and calling us to good works.

A very positive and promising dialogue between the Catholic Church and the Anglican Communion, conducted by the *Anglican and Roman Catholic International Commission* (ARCIC), has produced a number of valuable documents. The Final Report of the first ARCIC on the three basic questions of Eucharist, Ministry and Authority was presented for official consideration. The 1988 Lambeth Conference found the statements on Eucharist and Ministry «consonant with Anglican tradition», while the section on Authority was seen as a good foundation for further discussion. A first Vatican response was not so positive, and it was possible only after much discussion within the Vatican for the Pontifical Council for Promoting Christian Unity to respond with a more encouraging reply. The discussions had led to «Clarifications», which in turn were accepted by ARCIC and eventually the Pontifical Council was able to confirm officially that no further

work needed to be done on the presentation of Anglican and Catholic faith in the Eucharist. It was possible to state also that there was agreement on the nature of Ministry in the Church, although the question of the person of the minister able to celebrate the Eucharist remained unsolved. Like the Anglican partner, the Catholic Church also saw the section of the *Final Report*, dealing with Authority in the Church, as most promising, but needing further study.

A second ARCIC has carried on the dialogue and has produced several excellent documents that have not as yet been submitted for official approval. I would like to mention especially:

- *The Church as Communion*, 1990, made a significant contribution to the present understanding of the Church as communion, a theme that has been taken up in a number of other dialogues and contexts;

- *Life in Christ: Morals, Communion and the Church*, 1993. Among the many international dialogues (bilateral and multilateral) between Christians, the Anglican-Roman Catholic International Commission was the first to have directly attempted a study on the subject of morals. The Commission had received many requests to take up this question since there was a growing belief that Roman Catholics and Anglicans are as much, if not more, divided on questions of morals as on doctrinal matters. As the then Presidents of ARCIC explained in an introduction to this report: «This belief in turn reflects the profound and true conviction that authentic Christian unity is as much a matter of life as of faith. Those who share one faith in Christ will share one life in Christ. Hence the title of this statement: *Life in Christ: Morals, Communion and the Church*».¹

- *The Gift of Authority*, 1999. As already mentioned, the question of authority in the Church was one of the three topics dealt with by ARCIC I in their *Final Report*. The statements there were seen to provide a good foundation for further study, and ARCIC II undertook such a study. The result, in the form of an agreed statement entitled *The Gift of Authority*, was published in 1999 and is a valuable contribution to a question that is of fundamental importance in all the dialogues. In this document, authority is seen as a gift that God gives to his Church and which calls for a response of «yes» from the members of that body. There is qualified acknowledgement of papal primacy, together with the need for greater collegiality. *The gift of Authority* challenges the Anglican Communion and the Catholic Church to move beyond their traditional differences of expression, so as to converge around their common basic understanding of authority. This means that

¹ Information Service (IS), Pontifical Council for Promoting Christian Unity, Vatican City, 85 (1994/I) 54.

the Anglican Communion would grow from opposition to the papal primacy to acceptance of a universal primacy, while the Catholic Church, in the spirit of the Second Vatican Council, would develop greater collegiality.

The most recent document of ARCIC II, published in 2004, considers the role of Mary in the life and doctrine of the Church, with special attention given to the dogmatic definitions of the Immaculate Conception and the Assumption. The Commission expressed the hope that the statement entitled: *Mary, Grace and Hope in Christ*, will make an ecumenical contribution of value, even beyond the partners of Anglican-Catholic dialogue. The place of the Blessed Virgin Mary in the life of the Church had been addressed briefly by ARCIC I in *Authority in the Church II* (1981), para. 30, and a considerable level of agreement had been registered there. The Marian dogmas of the Assumption and the Immaculate Conception, together with the practice of invoking Mary in intercessory prayer, remained as areas of divergence. It was principally with the aim of addressing these particular areas of Marian doctrine and devotion that ARCIC II took up a special study of the role of Mary in the faith and practice of the Church.

With reference to the dogma of the Assumption of Mary, the agreed statement notes that «we can together affirm that God took the Blessed Virgin Mary, in the fullness of her personal being, into his glory». The text proceeds to affirm: «what this definition teaches about Mary is not contrary to the teaching of Scripture, but received support from it, and can only be understood in the light of Scripture».

With regard to the content of the dogma of the Immaculate Conception, the agreed statement affirms that in Mary's acceptance of the divine will one can see «her prior preparation from the very beginning of her existence». Hence the Commission «can together affirm that God was at work in Mary from her mother's womb, preparing her for the unique vocation of bearing in her own flesh the new Adam «in whom all things in heaven and earth hold together» (Colossians 1:17)». Again here, the dogma is declared not to be contrary to Scripture, but to receive support from it. The Commission has looked at the doctrines themselves, and has not finalized its treatment of the authoritative claims of dogmatic definitions. Experience within the *Ecumenical Society of the Blessed Virgin Mary*, an English-based society, indicates that there is indeed reason to hope that in due course Mary will be seen by the Christian Churches not as an obstacle to unity, but as a «Mother of God and Icon of the Church, the spiritual Mother who intercedes for Christ's disciples and all humanity» (UUS 79).

When the *Joint International Commission for the Theological Dialogue between the Catholic Church and the Orthodox Church* was established in 1979, great hopes were expressed in the possibility of this dialogue rapidly bringing these ancient Churches together again in the full communion of

the first Christian millennium. During the following ten years, the Commission did excellent work and produced three documents mainly regarding the sacramental life of the Catholic and Orthodox Churches.²

As a result, it was possible for Pope John Paul II and the Ecumenical Patriarch Dimitrios I to state in 1987 «the Catholic Church and the Orthodox Church can already profess together that common faith in the mystery of the Church and the bond between faith and sacraments». They also affirmed that «in these Churches apostolic succession is fundamental for the sanctification and the unity of the people of God» (UUS 59).

When the Commission met in Munich, in 1990, it had before it a new document that dealt with authority in the Church. It was expected that this document, which earlier in the year had received the approval of the Coordinating Committee of the Dialogue, would have brought the two partners close to discussing the fundamental reason for their divisions, namely the position of the Roman Pontiff in the exercise of authority in the universal Church. Unfortunately, this paper was never discussed. The fall of communism in Central and Eastern Europe had re-opened in those areas an old and bitter source of division, namely the existence in traditional Orthodox territories of a Church in full communion with Rome, following Orthodox traditions but not in communion with the Patriarch of that territory. The Communist regimes in the Soviet Union and Romania had declared these Churches illegal and confiscated their properties. Now they were able to return to life legally and to reclaim their former churches and other confiscated property, much of which was by this time in Orthodox hands. By June 1990, the situation in the Western Ukraine and in Romania had become tense and relations there severely strained.

The question of what is called 'Uniatism' had been present, in one form or another, since the first plenary session of the Commission (Patmos-Rhodes 1980), and was scheduled to be discussed at a later stage in the dialogue. The Theological Commission was not really the place to deal with certain aspects of the problems that were being faced in Eastern Europe, but was given no option by the Orthodox partner. A 'Statement' was prepared by the dialogue Commission and published at the close of the meeting.

For the Orthodox Churches, the time had come for the whole question of 'Uniatism' to be discussed and hopefully condemned. The Catholic members of the Commission, on the other hand, could not see how any dis-

² *The Mystery of the Church and of the Eucharist in the light of the Mystery of the Holy Trinity* (Munich, 1982), IS 49 (1982/II-III) 107-112; *Faith, Sacraments and the Unity of the Church* (Bari, 1987), IS 64 (1987/II) 82-87; *The Sacrament of Order in the Sacramental Structure of the Church, with Particular Reference to the Importance of the Apostolic Succession for the Sanctification and Unity of the People of God* (26 June 1988), IS 68 (1988/III-IV) 173-178.

cussion on this subject could be successful unless there had first been dialogue on the role of the Roman Pontiff in the Universal Church. In 1991 the Coordinating committee of the Dialogue prepared a draft document for consideration at the next Plenary, entitled: *Uniatism, method of union of the past, and the present search for full communion*.³

The Plenary met at Balamand, in Lebanon, in 1993, and approved an agreed statement. This was not an attempt to solve the problem, but rather to bring back a climate of peace in the troubled areas of Central and Eastern Europe, so that the formal theological dialogue could be resumed. Known as the «Balamand Document» from the place of meeting, the text is based on three fundamental principles:

a) «The inviolable freedom of persons and their obligation to follow the requirements of their conscience» (N° 15). This principle is the basis of the whole document, and justifies both the personal choice to adhere to the Catholic Church or to the Orthodox Church, and offers the possibility of returning to the Catholic Church for those communities which in 1945-1949 had been forced by Communist regimes to become part of the Orthodox Church, as happened in the Ukraine, Romania and Slovakia.

b) «The right of the Oriental Catholic Churches to exist and to act in answer to the spiritual needs of their faithful» (N° 3).

c) «*Uniatism* is not the present method in the search for full unity» (N° 4). The document states: «On each side it is recognized that what Christ has entrusted to his Church – profession of the apostolic faith, participation in the same sacraments, above all the one priesthood celebrating the one sacrifice of Christ, the apostolic succession of bishops – cannot be considered the exclusive property of one of our Churches» (N° 13).

From this the document draws the two following conclusions:

– the local Catholic and Orthodox Churches recognize each other as «Sister Churches» that have the responsibility to work for the restoration of unity between them (cf. N° 14);

– «in this context it is clear that any re-baptism must be avoided» (N° 13).

The document then seeks to give some *Practical Rules*, based on the above ecclesiological principles with a view to overcoming the tense relationships between Orthodox and Eastern Catholics in certain places, and in the hope of encouraging a genuine growth in «mutual respect between the Churches which find themselves in difficult situations» (N° 19).

Some Orthodox Churches unfortunately rejected the Balamand document. In fact the church of Greece and five other Orthodox Churches (Jerusalem, Serbia, Bulgaria, Georgia, Czech Republic and Slovakia) had

³ IS 78 (1991/III-IV) 204.

refused to participate in the Balamand meeting and were not at all happy with the agreed statement. Some objections came also from the Romanian Greek-Catholic Church, but the Ukrainian Major Archbishop, Cardinal Lubachivsky, immediately accepted the document. The Balamand document receives a positive presentation in the Encyclical *Ut Unum Sint* (N° 60) and in the common Declaration signed by Pope John Paul II and Patriarch Bartholomew I at the conclusion of the Patriarch's visit to Rome in June 1995.⁴

The next Plenary was due to be held in Rome in 1996, but no agreement could be reached on the theme for such a meeting. For the Catholic partner, it was time to return to the theological dialogue and discuss the document prepared and approved by the coordinating committee in 1990. The Orthodox partner refused, however, to discuss any question other than *Uniatism* until further progress would be made towards the final solution to this problem. The coordinating committee met at Arrichia, just outside of Rome, in June 1999 and a full meeting of the Commission followed in Baltimore in May 2000. It proved impossible, however, to move beyond Balamand and the international dialogue remained suspended until 2005. A plenary meeting of the Commission in Belgrade in September 2006 took up the document that had been prepared for Munich in 1990, and reports indicate that the meeting was held in a fraternal atmosphere and made progress in considering the document presented there. A further meeting is planned for 2007.

This experience shows how difficult theological dialogue can be when the partners bring along with them sad memories of former centuries and old suspicions that destroy mutual trust. Without the latter there can be no genuine dialogue. Similarly, there can be little hope of a positive outcome when there is no agreement on the agenda to be followed. On the most fundamental level of doctrine and sacraments, Catholics and Orthodox see themselves as closer to each other than to any other Church or Christian community. As Cardinal Kasper told the plenary meeting of the members of the Pontifical Council for Promoting Christian Unity in November 2003: «We are very close to these churches in terms of faith, sacraments and Episcopal ministry, and we are bound to them in a «community of faith and charity», in «family ties which ought to thrive between local churches, as between sisters»». Experience with regard to Orthodox-Catholic relations shows, however, that there is nothing so delicate and potentially painful as a family feud. The stakes, moreover, are particularly high, since the possibility of full and visible communion is real. The present improvement in

⁴ IS 91 (1996/ I-II) 10

these relations owes much to the efforts made by the Pontifical Council for Promoting Christian Unity after 2000 to foster relations with the Orthodox Churches individually. Other important factors have been the shared realization of the Orthodox and Catholic Churches of a common growing threat from the spirit of secularism and relativism in the modern world, and their effect particularly on Europe.

Undoubtedly, the main problem that faces the Orthodox and Catholic Churches in their search for full communion is the relationship between the Bishop of Rome and the Orthodox Churches. The Pontifical Council organized in May 2003 an academic symposium on the Petrine ministry. Relations were presented by both a Catholic and an Orthodox scholar for each of the four themes chosen for consideration during this meeting. It is expected that the Acts of this symposium will be published and should be a valuable contribution to a question that is of fundamental importance for all theological dialogue in which the Catholic Church is engaged.

Other dialogues have also produced important documents, but these have not been submitted for official acceptance by the Churches concerned. The above have been treated in some detail as a sign of hope for the future and an explanation of the statement of Pope John Paul II who thanks the Lord that he has led us to make progress along «the path of unity and communion between Christians, a path difficult but so full of joy» (UUS 2).

State of the Question

I have no doubt that, were the Council Fathers able to observe the results of their groundbreaking decisions, forty years after the publication of their Decree *Unitatis Redintegratio*, they would be more than satisfied. The new spirit of fellowship that exists today among the Christian communities is a sure sign that their work was inspired by the Holy Spirit, who has since guided those involved in giving life to the Decree *Unitatis Redintegratio*.

One event in particular illustrates this vividly, namely the opening of the Holy Door of the Roman Basilica of St. Paul's Outside the Walls on January 16, 2000. No-one at the Second Vatican Council would surely have imagined the Bishop of Rome, with the Archbishop of Canterbury at his right and the representative of the Ecumenical Patriarch at his left, together opening that Holy Door, in the presence of leaders and representatives of ten other Orthodox Churches, five Oriental Orthodox Churches, the Old Catholic Church – Union of Utrecht, the Lutheran World Federation, the World Methodist Council, the Disciples of Christ, Pentecostals and the World Council of Churches.

This was the result of the constant effort of the Christian communities, with the Catholic Church playing a leading role, to work together in the cause of Christian Unity at both the international and the local levels, through prayer, common witness and theological dialogue. There has been a rich exchange of gifts, from which all have undoubtedly benefited.

There have been disappointments and the road ahead towards full, visible communion between the Christian communities remains difficult and arduous. In fact, some of those involved in the search for unity have become frustrated with a progress that they consider far too slow, and have even opted for a unity that would concentrate on cooperation and common witness, leaving unsolved doctrinal differences. For the Second Vatican Council the communion we seek calls for unity in faith, sacramental life and ministry, a visible, organic unity. This has also been the aim of the World Council of Churches, and in particular of the Faith and Order Commission of that body.

Despite the problems encountered in the search for unity, Pope John Paul II in his Encyclical *Ut Unum Sint* once again committed the Catholic Church to the goal of full visible unity among all the baptised (N° 77). This unity, however, is not to be understood as uniformity. In fact, the unity of the Church is realised in the midst of a rich diversity, a diversity that is a dimension of the Church's catholicity. The Second Vatican Council made it clear that the unity that we seek by no means requires the sacrifice of the rich diversity of spirituality, discipline, liturgical rites and elaboration of revealed truth that has grown up among Christians to the degree that this diversity remains faithful to the apostolic tradition (cf. UR 4 and 15-16). The principle is clear; the application more difficult. Again in his Encyclical on *Commitment to Ecumenism*, Pope John Paul II states that «in the journey towards the necessary and sufficient visible unity, in the communion of the one Church willed by Christ [...] «one must not impose any burden beyond that which is strictly necessary» (cf. *Acts* 15:28)» (UUS 78).

One of the great disappointments for the Catholic Church in its commitment of Christian Unity has come from developments in the Anglican Communion. Already during the Second Vatican Council, hopes were evident of an early return to full communion between Rome and Canterbury. The ARCIC I dialogue seemed to confirm this. The question of the validity of Anglican Orders, however, remained a problem and became even more divisive as women were admitted in the Anglican Communion to the priesthood, and even ordained to the episcopacy.

A special Consultation in Mississauga, Toronto, in May 2000, recommended that a new International Anglican-Roman Catholic Working group be set up of eight members (of whom four would be bishops) from each side. The *International Anglican-Roman Catholic Commission for Unity and Mission* (IARCCUM) was officially launched at the end of 2001 in Lambeth

Palace, London and in Rome, and received strong encouragement for its work from both Archbishop of Carey of Canterbury and Pope John Paul II. Work would be directed towards areas in which it seemed further progress towards visible unity between the Anglican Communion and the Roman Catholic Church would strengthen the mission of the Church of Christ. In particular, work began in 2002 on preparing a first draft of a «common declaration which would formally express the degree of agreement in faith that already exists between Anglicans and Catholics, consolidate the results of more than thirty years of dialogue and commit the dialogue partners to a deeper sharing in common life and witness».⁵

Other areas of study would focus on practical recommendations for facilitating the on-going process of ecumenical reception, with special attention to the reception of ARCIC documents, while attention would be given to pastoral and practical strategies to help the two communions, especially in local contexts, to do together even now whatever is possible in the actual stage of real but imperfect communion.

A second meeting of the Commission was held in Malta from 19-23 November 2002. The work already done was discussed thoroughly and practical proposals made especially for the reception of ARCIC texts through mutual study and understanding, rather than by formal response.⁶ After a third meeting in 2003, IARCCUM suffered a severe setback, as a result of difficulties which the Anglican Communion was experiencing as a consequence of deep divisions among the Provinces with regard to the priestly ordination of practicing homosexual ministers, and even of Gene Robinson, an openly-gay priest, as Bishop of New Hampshire. The Primates of the Anglican Communion met at Lambeth in October 2003 and decided to set up a commission to examine how to create order in the Church. The Anglican Communion being in such disarray, and indeed in danger of breaking-up, the members of IARCCUM, in November 2003 decided to suspend temporarily their Commission's activity, so as to leave the Anglican Communion room to find a solution to its own internal problems, before proceeding further. IARCCUM has recently been able to meet again to study a 'common declaration' of faith. A visit to Rome by the present Archbishop of Canterbury is expected to take place in late 2006.

Cardinal Walter Kasper, President of the Pontifical Council for Promoting Christian Unity, has acknowledged the great progress that has been made in this search, but also spoke of the difficult path ahead.

..., if we look at the world with objectivity, we can't pretend that everything is

⁵ *IS* 111 (2002/IV) 230.

⁶ *Ibid.*

perfect. Sometimes we note feelings of ecumenical exhaustion, signs of new confessionalism, attempts to mine the path to unity. After having filled in the trenches that at one time divided us, we find them opening up anew in the field of ethics.

The Cardinal admitted that from a human point of view there are reasons for concern and losing hope. On the other hand, he said, Christians are people of hope. When the Spirit of God starts something, he always sees it through to completion.⁷

Pope Benedict XVI in an address to the Christian World Communions, on October 27, 2006, spoke of «the unity in Christ which we seek». He went on to encourage those present in this search:

However daunting the journey, we must not lose sight of the final goal: full, visible communion in Christ and in the Church. We may feel discouraged when progress is slow, but there is too much at stake to turn back. On the contrary, there are good reasons to forge ahead, as my predecessor Pope John Paul II pointed out in his Encyclical Letter «*Ut Unum Sint*» on the Catholic Church's ecumenical commitment, where he speaks of brotherhood rediscovered and greater solidarity in the service of humanity.

The Apostle assures us that the Spirit helps us in our weakness. Though there are many difficulties to be overcome, we firmly believe that the Holy Spirit is ever present and will guide us along the right path.

Coachwood Drive, 16
Warabrook
NSW 2304
Australia

EDWARD IDRIS Cardinal CASSIDY

⁷ Osservatore Romano, English Edition, N. 5, 4 February 2004, 5.

SUMMARY

With the Decree *Unitatis Redintegratio*, the Second Vatican Council called on the Catholic Church to «recognise the signs of the times and take an active and intelligent part in the work of ecumenism». This involved a radical change in the life of the Catholic Church. Forty years later, how has the Catholic Church responded to this challenge? Much has been achieved. A new relationship has been forged, a brotherhood rediscovered. Yet, much remains to be done, and while old trenches that divided Christians have been filled in, new divisions have opened especially in the field of ethics. The path to unity and communion between Christians, to quote Pope John Paul II, I «is difficult but so full of joy» (*Ut Unum Sint*, 2).

Con il Decreto *Unitatis Redintegratio*, il Concilio Vaticano II ha esortato la Chiesa cattolica a «riconoscere i segni dei tempi e a partecipare in modo attivo ed intelligente all'opera ecumenica». Questo impegno ha comportato un radicale cambiamento nella vita della Chiesa cattolica. Quarant'anni dopo, possiamo chiederci come la Chiesa cattolica ha riposto a questa sfida. Molto è stato fatto. Un nuovo stile di relazione si è realizzato, la fraternità è stata riscoperta. Tuttavia, molto resta ancora da fare, e sebbene antichi divari che separavano i cristiani siano stati colmati, nuove divisione sono sorte, specialmente nella fera della morale. Con le parole di Papa Giovanni Paolo II, il cammino dell'unità e della comunione tra i cristiani è un cammino «difficile, ma tanto ricco di gioia» (*Ut Unum Sint*, 2).